unresolved power tussle between Sukhu loyalists and the camp led by state party chief Pratibha Singh keeps it in a state of full motor paralysis.

Masking or perhaps mirroring that disarray, Sukhu threw a googly on July 10. He deferred the seat reservation roster for local body polls, saying it could not be decided in the absence of fresh census data on precise caste demographics. That earned him a reprimand from the Election Commission. Expect the usual rhetoric before that settles down. But this deflection of spotlight stems from acute need.

FRACTURED FRONTLINE

Flood relief offers a spot of political relief. Bulldozers are working to clear landslides, and temporary bridges springing up across torrential nullahs.

ANI



HP Congress chief Pratibha Singh at a flood-affected site in Mandi, Jul. 6

But the ruling party itself presents a devastation zone, with too many broken bridges. District- and block-level units were dissolved way back in November 2024. So was the entire Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC). These have not yet been reconstituted. Doing so may seem like primary healthcare, but it's infinitely complicated by the factionalism.

The BJP, sensing the vacuum, has wasted no time in deploying its full infantry. Former CM Jairam Thakur has been crisscrossing the state, lending weight to the BJP's own relief efforts, sharpening its narrative for local body polls—and down the winding hill road, for the 2027 assembly election. Last December, its mandal-level network got a higher degree of resolution, going from 74 units to 171.

The Congress's top-heavy, ad hoc mode of functioning offers a stark contrast. It scarcely hides the fracture, which is more than hairline. Sukhu holds sway over the government and has built his own support base. But Pratibha, 69-year-old widow of ex-CM Virbhadra Singh, continues to command emotional and political loyalty in key regions and, with minister-son Vikramaditya, has not been above dangling the threat of donning saffron to browbeat the high command.

In public, Sukhu promises a functional coexistence that doesn't work in reality. Earlier this year, in a bid to mirror the BJP's structure, his side proposed increasing district units from 13 to 17 and block units from 68 to 140. A wary Pratibha camp resisted, saying it should be the PCC chief's call.

In March, at a 'summit meet' in Delhi, 16 AICC observers, most new to the state's political currents, strove in vain to create a consensus. The high command sticks to playing referee rather than enforcer: the cross-voting by six MLAs in last year's Rajya Sabha polls is still fresh in memory. Its only move came in February, when Rajiv Shukla was replaced by Rajya Sabha MP Rajni Patil as state in-charge. Not enough to set the grassroots on fire. ■

Takeaways

- **Flood relief has become the primary arena for political showmanship for all sides**
- **Sukhu has earned credit for his visible ground presence**
- **That only masks an utter devastation at the grassroots: its district- and block-level units still stand dissolved**

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

ON THE NIGHT OF JULY 14, Soumyashree Bisi, a 20-year-old student from Fakir Mohan Autonomous College in Balasore, succumbed to over 90 per cent burns at AIIMS Bhubaneswar. A shocker that became only the latest proof of a collapsing institutional machinery in Odisha—a chilling series of cases that includes a relapse to brutal custom, caste atrocities, violent insubordination, besides a surge in gender violence.

Bisi had set herself ablaze on her campus two days earlier, allegedly driven to desperation by the failure of authorities to act on her repeated complaints of sexual harassment against her professor, Samir Sahu. She had made every possible attempt to seek help: writing to the principal, lodging a formal complaint with an internal committee, reaching out to the Union education minister, the CM's Office, even personally meeting Balasore MP Pratap Sarangi. But the silence of the system was deafening. As ex-CM Naveen Patnaik wrote in a social media post, "If even one person had taken responsibility...perhaps the girl's life could have been saved."

His indictment joined a burst of national outrage. Even President Droupadi Murmu visited AIIMS, hours before the student's death. CM Mohan Charan Majhi promised the "strictest punishment" and announced an ex gratia of Rs 20 lakh. The principal and the accused professor were suspended and arrested. But this flurry of post-facto activity did little to stem the fury. The Congress called a statewide bandh, while Rahul Gandhi said it was "not a suicide, but a systematic murder by the BJP's system".

Barely a year after reins passed to the BJP, Odisha seems to be in the grip of a near-anarchic spell few had anticipated. The Majhi government's tenure has coincided